

IN CONTEXT

La Madeleine

The church of La Madeleine (dedicated to Mary Magdalene) is one of the great landmarks of Paris. It was conceived by Napoleon as a memorial to the glory of the French army and takes the form of an enormous Roman temple. However, it was transformed into a parish church and consecrated in 1842. Its magnificent organ was designed by Aristide Cavaillé-Coll, the 19th century's most famous organ builder. Saint-Saëns held the highly prestigious post of organist there from 1858 to 1877. His successors included his pupil Gabriel Fauré, who was organist between 1896 and 1905.



THE CHURCH OF THE MADELEINE, c. 1910,
HAND-COLORED PHOTOGRAPH

Camille Saint-Saëns was born in Paris into a middle-class family. A piano-playing aunt gave him his first music lessons when he